

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Sikhism as a lived religion in the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are two sections: Beliefs and Teachings; Practices.

Students will be expected to study Sikhism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian.

Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity and Sikhism:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.4)*
- The practice and significance of worship (2.5)*.

Students should recognise that Sikhism is one of the many religious traditions in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam and Judaism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content. Students should also recognise that within Sikhism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Sikhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Khalsa and non-Khalsa Sikhs.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs and practices to Sikhs today should be explored throughout the two sections.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of God: how the characteristics of God are shown in the Mool Mantar, Guru Granth Sahib 1, and why the characteristics are important and why the Mool Mantar is significant for Sikhs.
1.2	God as Creator: the nature and importance of God as Creator (Karta Purakh) for Sikhs; Sikh teachings on God as Creator, including Guru Granth Sahib 12 and 94.
1.3	The nature of human life: the purpose and significance of life as an opportunity to unite with God; Sikh understandings of why uniting with God is important; how uniting with God will affect their lives, including Guru Granth Sahib 12.
1.4*	Sikh beliefs about life after death: the nature of karma, rebirth and mukti (liberation); how they are shown in the Guru Granth Sahib, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 2 and 78; divergent understandings of how and why karma, rebirth and mukti are important for Sikh life today.
1.5	Purpose of life: the nature and importance of being gurmukh (God-centred) not manmukh (self-centred) and the elimination of haumai (ego/pride), including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 125 and 226; what actions make a gurmukh Sikh; divergent understandings of why being gurmukh and eliminating haumai is important in Sikh life today.
1.6	The oneness of humanity: how the equality of all humans is shown in the Guru Granth Sahib, including Guru Granth Sahib 349; how equality is shown in stories from the lives of the Gurus, including the example of Mai Bhago and the appointment of women as teachers; and how equality is shown in Sikh life today; how and why complete equality of men and women is important for Sikhs today.
1.7	Sewa (service to others): the nature of sewa, including tan, man and dhan; the origins and purpose of sewa and its importance in the development of Sikhism, including Guru Granth Sahib 26; divergent understandings of the practice and importance of sewa in Sikh life today in reflecting the priority of service to others.
1.8	Sangat: the nature and history of the sangat; divergent understandings of why the sangat is important for Sikhs, including Guru Granth Sahib 1316; the concept of Sat Sangat and divergent understandings of its significance for Sikhs; problems for Sikhs living without a sangat.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Features of the gurdwara: the nature, history and purpose of the design of the Gurdwara as the 'Door/Gate of the Guru', including Rahit Maryada Chapters 4–6; how and why objects of devotion are used within the gurdwara: Guru Granth Sahib, takht, chanani, chaur, the langar hall, four doors, and the Nishan Sahib; divergent understandings of the importance of these features in Sikh life today.
2.2	The gurdwara: the role and importance of the gurdwara within the Sikh community, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 1391; activities that take place within the gurdwara and why; the nature and importance of visiting Sikh historical gurdwaras: the Harmandir Sahib in Amritsar (the Golden Temple).
2.3	Langar: the history of langar, including Guru Granth Sahib 967; the nature and purposes of langar; the significance of langar for Sikhs today, especially as an expression of sewa.
2.4	Nam Japna – meditating on the name of God: the nature and significance of Nam Japna; diverse ways in which the Nam Japna is used in the gurdwara and in Sikh daily life, including Guru Granth Sahib 1142.
2.5*	Prayer, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 305: the nature, role and purpose of prayer in the home; the different types of prayer; when prayer might take place and why; the importance of having different prayers.
2.6	Akhand path (continuous 48-hour reading of the Guru Granth Sahib): the nature, history, role and purpose of the akhand path, including reference Rahit Maryada Chapter 7; how and why Sikhs might take part in the akhand path: why the akhand path is important for the Sikh community and for individual Sikhs.
2.7	Gurpurbs and commemorations: divergent understandings of the nature, history and purpose of gurpurbs and commemorations; why they are important for Sikhs today. The origins and meaning of gurpurbs, including Guru Nanak's birthday, Vaisakhi, including reference to the account of the events found in Gurbilas Patshahi 10. Divali: the origins and meaning of commemorations, including the martyrdom of Guru Arjan and Guru Tagh Bahadur Ji.
2.8	Birth and naming rituals and ceremonies: the celebration and significance of Naam Karan and Hukamnama; the significance of Amrit Sanskar (the initiation ceremony) for Sikh families, including reference to the Rahit Maryada Chapters 11 and 13; divergent understandings of these ceremonies between khalsa and non-khalsa Sikhs; the significance of the names Singh and Kaur in the naming and Amrit ceremonies, and for Sikh identity today.